

The following passage from the *Catechism of the Catholic Church*
describes the kind of view I want to discuss:

1038. The resurrection of all the dead, "of both the just and the unjust," will precede the Last Judgment. ... Christ will come "in his glory, and all the angels with him Before him will be gathered all the nations, and he will separate them one from another as a shepherd separates the sheep from the goats, and he will place the sheep at his right hand, but the goats at the left.... and they will go away into eternal punishment, but the righteous into eternal life."

One topic often associated with belief in God is the topic of life after death.

This certainly seems like a picture according to which, after death, God passes judgement on all of us, and on the basis of our life, decides that some of us will go to heaven forever, and some others to hell forever. (If not 'forever', then the talk of the **last** judgement wouldn't make much sense.)

Our first question today is: is what we are told about life after death by many of the major monotheistic religions compatible with the existence of a perfectly good God?

Here is what Ted Sieder says about this kind of view:

Let's try to lay out Sider's reasoning by isolating the various features of the **traditional doctrine** of heaven and hell that he thinks are inconsistent with the existence of a perfectly good God.



the
paradox of
heaven and
hell



replies to the
paradox



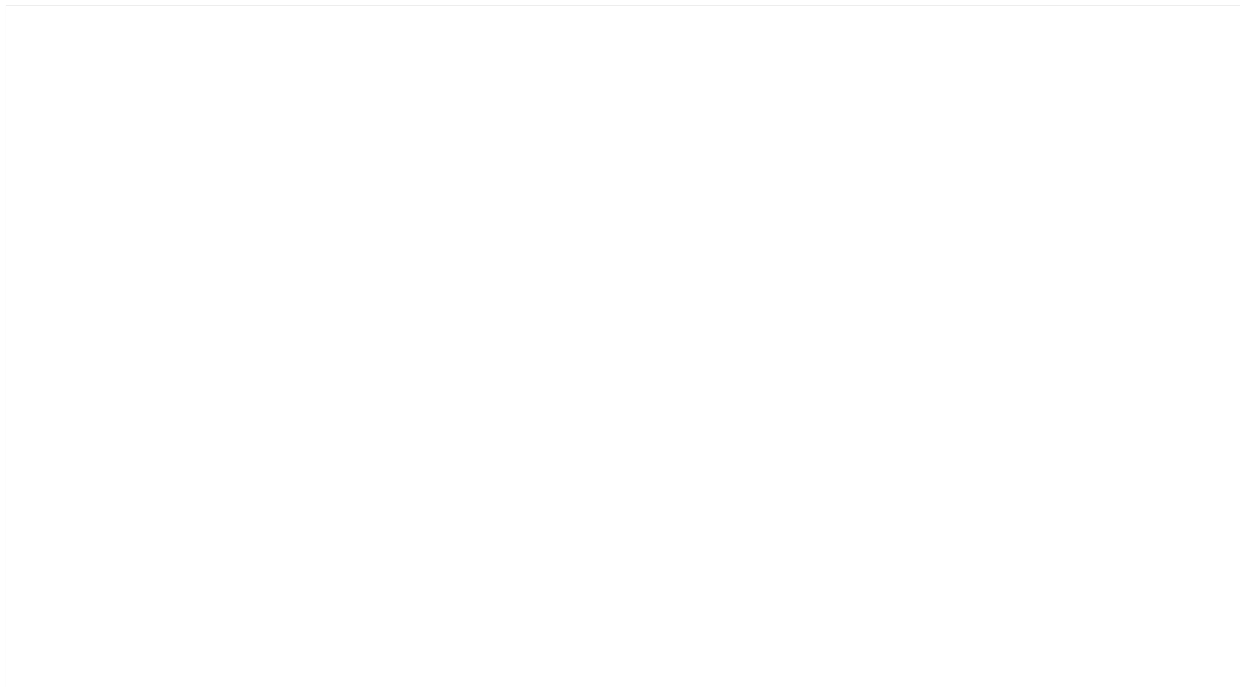
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not worth
living

A certain traditional conception of the afterlife is binary. After death one proceeds either to heaven or hell. Heaven is very, very good; hell is very, very bad. There are no possibilities for the afterlife other than heaven and hell, and membership in heaven or hell is never indeterminate or a matter of degree.

The problem with the binary conception is that it contradicts God's justice. God must employ some criterion to decide who goes to heaven and who goes to hell. No reasonable criterion would be sharp; any reasonable criterion will have borderline cases. But the binary conception of the afterlife allows for no corresponding fuzziness in how the dead are to be treated. Hell must therefore contain people who are nearly indiscernible in relevant respects from people in Heaven. No just God would allow such a monstrously unfair thing.

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It is part of the traditional doctrine that God decides whether people go to

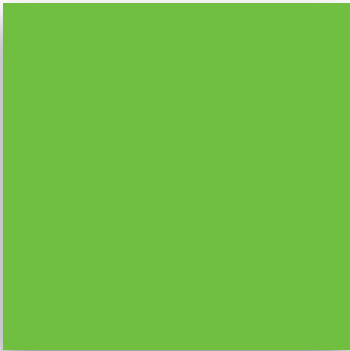
heaven and hell based on certain properties of these people. We will have

Let's call them the relevant properties.

open for what those properties might be; just have a name for them,



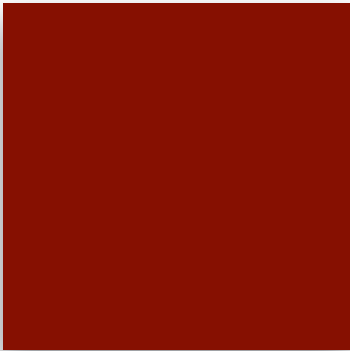












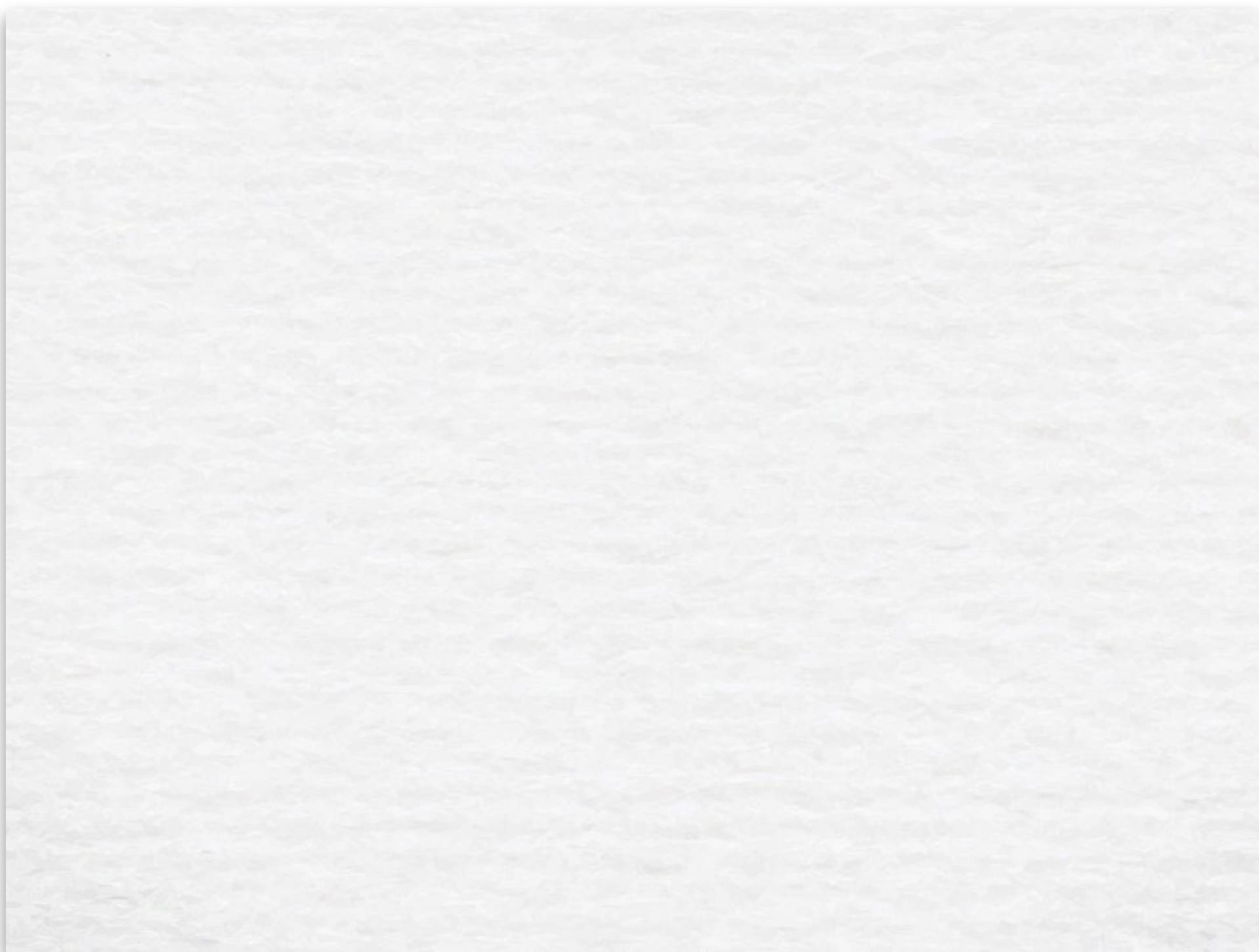
seems to give the defender of the afterlife further main options.



It seems difficult to deny Justice, Badness, or Divine Control. So that







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bad. There are no pros in it for the anti-

Dear Sir, I have the honor to acknowledge the receipt of your letter of the 11th inst. in relation to the matter of the 1st inst. and in reply to inform you that the same has been forwarded to the proper authorities for their consideration. I am, Sir, very respectfully,
Yours, very truly,
J. H. [Signature]

contradict God's justice. God must employ some

earliest and latest which goes to heaven and which goes

or hell is never in that air of degree.

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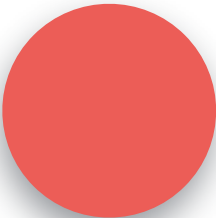
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Turned-in showed why it is plausible that respo to the argument from evil

must depend on the possibility of life after death. We will now ask: is the kind of

view of life after death we get here on pain of being perfectly good?



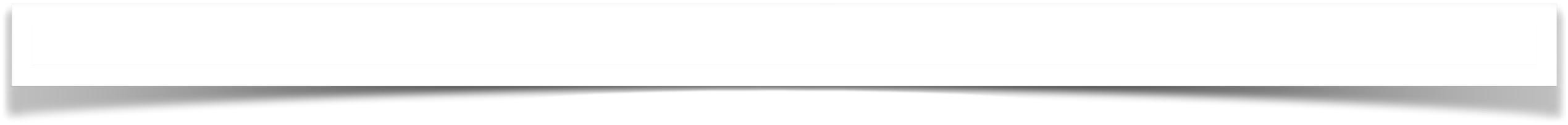
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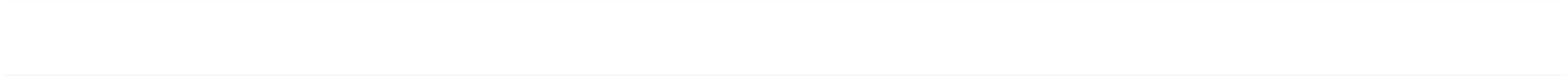
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Dichotomy: there are exactly two states in the afterlife, heaven and hell.



very similar in relevant respects."

Proportionality: justice is proportional, in that it 'prohibits very unequal treatment of persons who are

some other people-group B-go to hell. By Dichotomy, it follows that group A is much better than group B. By Dichotomy, it

By Non-universality and Divine control, it follows that God decides that some people - call them group A - go to heaven and that

way of dividing people into groups A and B which do not place people who are relevantly very similar into different groups

which not place people who are relevantly similar into different groups. So by justice, it follows that there must be some

follows that every human being is either in group A or group B. By Propriety (given that the people in group A are much, much

better off than the ones in group B), it follows that if God is just, there must be way of dividing people into group A and B

Justice: God's judgement about what goes to heaven & hell is just.

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